EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Keep the subscription: Netflix keeps adding titles, and its film additions lean on older releases

2,014
titles added in 2019, the busiest full year, up from 429 in 2016

75% → 40%
of films added within a year of release, 2016 against 2021

67%
of TV series on Netflix have only one season

The question

With the cost of living rising, is Netflix still worth paying for? What has it been adding, and does that suit how I watch?

The evidence

A public list of every title on Netflix in September 2021, with the date each was added: 8,804 titles after cleaning 8,809 raw rows.

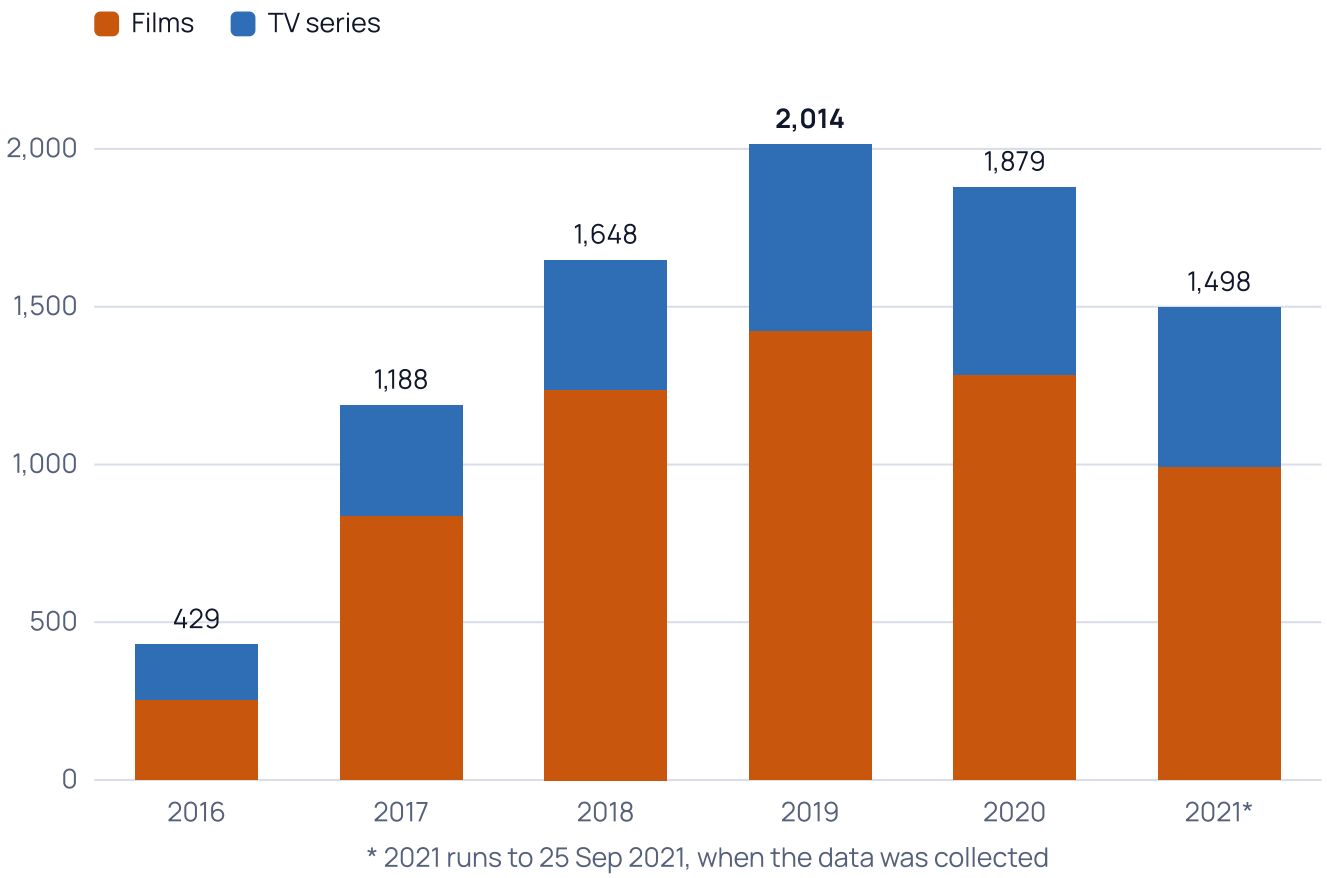
The answer

- Netflix added far more titles each year from 2016 to 2019, and kept a high pace after.
- Fresh releases shifted towards series, while film additions relied more on older titles.
- As someone who enjoys re-watching older films, I kept my subscription.

FINDING 1

Netflix added almost five times as many titles in 2019 as in 2016, and kept up the pace

Titles added each year



* 2021 runs to 25 Sep 2021, when the data was collected

- **Growth.** Additions grew from 429 titles in 2016 to 2,014 in 2019.
- **Still busy.** 2021, up to 25 September, was 10% ahead of the same period in 2020.
- **Mostly films.** Films make up 70% of the catalogue (6,129 of 8,804 titles).

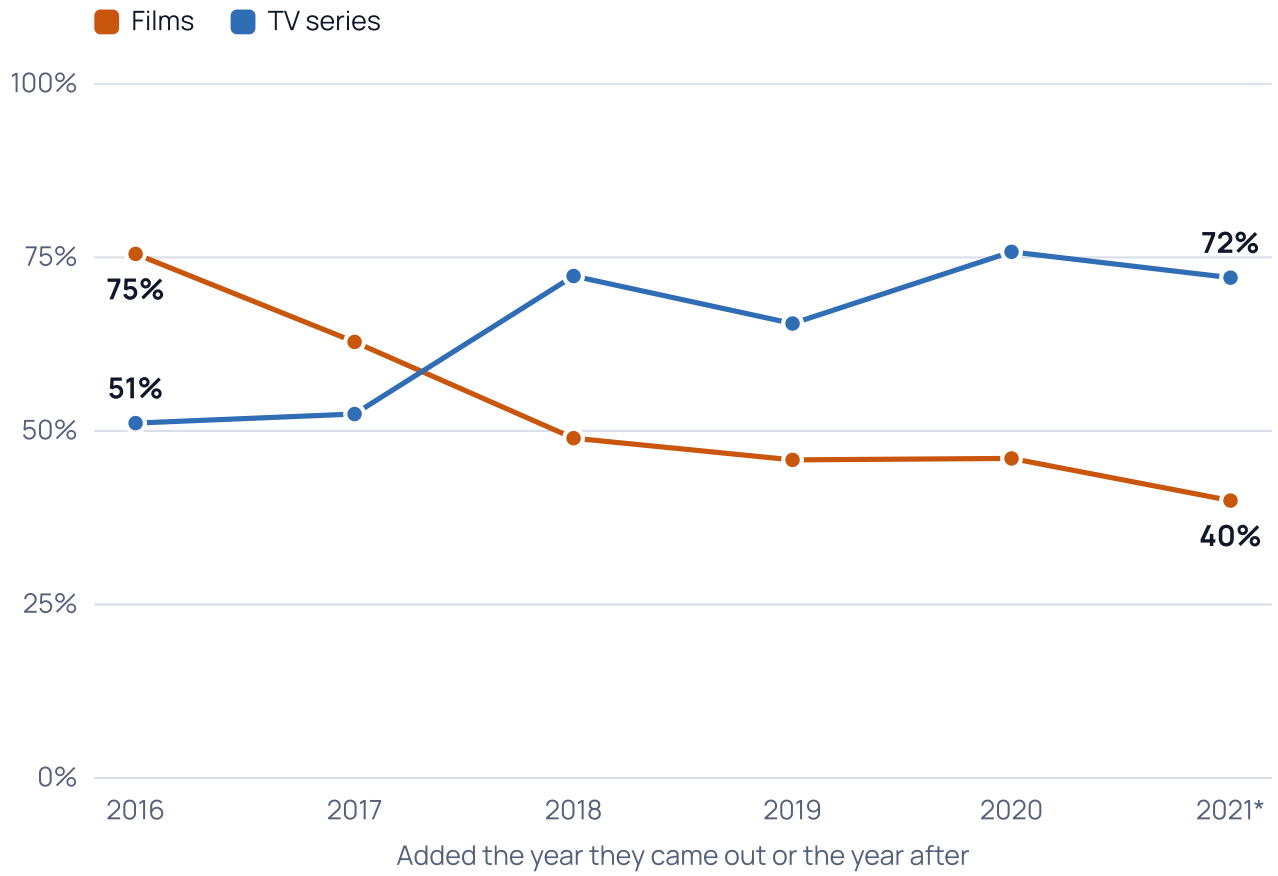
SO WHAT

The catalogue is not standing still, so the subscription keeps bringing something new to watch.

FINDING 2

New releases moved to series, while film additions turned towards older titles

Share of titles added within a year of release



- **Films:** in 2016, 75% of the films added had come out that year or the year before. By 2021 it was 40%.
- **TV series** went the other way, from 51% to 72%.
- **Short series:** 67% of the TV series have only one season.

SO WHAT

Netflix now leans on series for what is new, and on its back catalogue for films, which suits re-watching older favourites.

THE DATA

Careful cleaning mattered, because small errors were easy to miss

8,809 → 8,804

titles after removing 3 duplicates and 2 rows added by hand in 2024

4

titles that Excel had turned into dates, restored to their real names

54.5%

of all titles are not adult-rated: they are rated for teens or younger

What was done

1. Fixed duplicates, mangled titles and 3 runtimes stored as age ratings.
2. Analysed when titles were added, how old they were then, and their genres, ratings and lengths.
3. Built a dashboard in Tableau, then rebuilt it in JavaScript for the website.

Why it matters

A film title turned into a date, or a duplicate a simple check misses, can quietly change a result. Checks on the data are what keep the conclusions valid.

DECISION

Keep paying, and re-check with the titles Netflix lists in Hong Kong today

What I decided

1. **Keep the subscription**
   New titles keep arriving, and older films, which I enjoy re-watching, make up more of the film additions.
2. **Re-check with current data**
   Update the dashboard with the titles Netflix lists in Hong Kong today.

Limits to keep in mind

- **A 2021 snapshot.** Titles removed before September 2021 are missing, which could under-count older films added in early years. The trend is a strong hint rather than proof.
- **Not today's catalogue.** What Netflix lists in Hong Kong now may differ, which the re-check would show.
- **Additions, not viewing.** The data shows what Netflix added, not what people watched.